

victory at beating the system when it comes to getting things totally free? Keep in mind that reality television isn't reality for most of us, but that doesn't mean we can't save money or obtain free items with our coupons.

Or, perhaps, is your interest in couponing more altruistic than that? Are you looking for a way to donate more to the local food pantry without breaking the budget? Would you love to make up inexpensive gift baskets with free health and beauty products?

Or is it as simple as you'd like to save some money on your grocery bill?

Maybe it just looks like a cool and fun thing to do?

Whatever your motives, the next step is to decide just how much time you want to involve in this new project.

TIME

Do you want to make this a full-time job, spending the majority of your waking hours online searching for deals, clipping coupons, organizing them, and then shopping at a half a dozen stores each week? This new endeavor can quickly become an obsession. All it takes is that one grocery cart filled to the brim with products that end up being free or nearly free after coupons, and you're hooked. And if you have access to double coupon stores in your area, then cartloads of free stuff is a very real possibility.

Would you prefer to have a life outside of couponing? Your husband and your children might have a say about the amount of time you put into couponing. In hindsight, gently lowering my toddler into an open recycling bin to retrieve stray coupon inserts, and trooping through alleys to tear off diaper box proofs of purchase might not have been the wisest or the